Royal College of Art
Postgraduate Art and Design

Programme Specification

1. General Information

Programme title:	Design Futures (full-time and part-time)
Award:	MDes
Qualification Framework level:	7
School/Department or equivalent:	School of Communication & Design
Campus location(s):	Battersea
Total UK credits:	180
Date valid from/to:	2026-27

2. Programme Philosophy

Welcome to the MDes Design Futures programme. As a student on the programme, you will reflect on the role of design within an interdisciplinary context to address global environmental and societal challenges. Whilst on the programme you will develop your knowledge and skills to address these large-scale complex problems.

Working both individually and with your peers you will explore the ways in which research, design and futures methods and strategies can support more resilient and ethical futures. This will include consideration of complex systems and methods for envisioning future opportunities to create strategies that innovate commercial, environmental and social entrepreneurial initiatives and enterprises.

On the programme, you will have the opportunity to choose from college-wide electives. These include, for example, units from the MDes (Master of Design), such as Design Resilience, Design Ethics, and Design Innovation, as well as units in teaching and learning from the MEd (Master of Education) and research methods units from the MRes (Master of Research). The electives are subject to availability.

The programme culminates in the design, planning and implementation of an independent research project. This project draws on the knowledge and skills you have developed on the programme, and it is expected that the outcomes of your independent research project will take a form related to a professional context, be this a report, conference paper, presentation or prototype.

3. Educational Aims and Learning Outcomes of the Programme

Programme Aims

- To reflect on the role of design within interdisciplinary contexts to address global environmental and societal challenges;
- To apply design and futures methods and strategies to develop resilient and ethical futures;
- To develop strategies and futures that identify the conditions for tackling wicked problems at different scales;
- To create design futures outcomes that innovate commercial, environmental and social entrepreneurial initiatives and enterprises.

Learning Outcomes

Upon successful completion of the programme, you will be expected to meet the requirements of both the College-wide Learning Outcomes and your programme-specific Learning Outcomes.

College-Wide Learning Outcomes

You should be able to:

- Interrogate and articulate the intentions of your work in relation to the critical and conceptual context of your field(s) of study;
- Independently plan and produce work that is informed by developments at the forefront of your field(s) of study;
- Evaluate and critique the principles and methods of research in your field(s) of study, and apply these principles to your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice;
- Demonstrate originality in how you translate knowledge into practice;
- Communicate your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice to a non-specialist audience;
- Critically reflect on the likely public impact of your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice, and on your responsibilities as a practitioner;
- Define your professional ambitions and identify the challenges involved in meeting them.

Programme-Specific Learning Outcomes

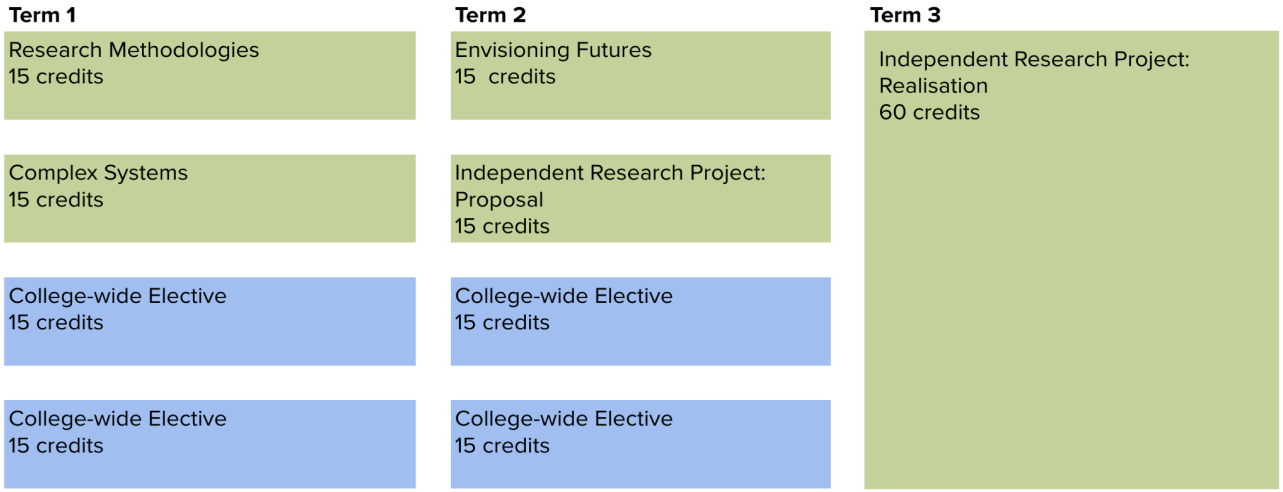
You should be able to:

- Articulate and apply design in an interdisciplinary context that addresses global environmental and societal challenges;
- Apply design, research, and futures methodologies and strategies to complex systems in order to support resilient and ethical futures;
- Apply design strategies and future thinking to tackle wicked problems;
- Propose design-led strategies that foster commercial, environmental and social entrepreneurial initiatives and enterprises;
- Develop a body of work in a specific field or context of professional, research or personal activity.

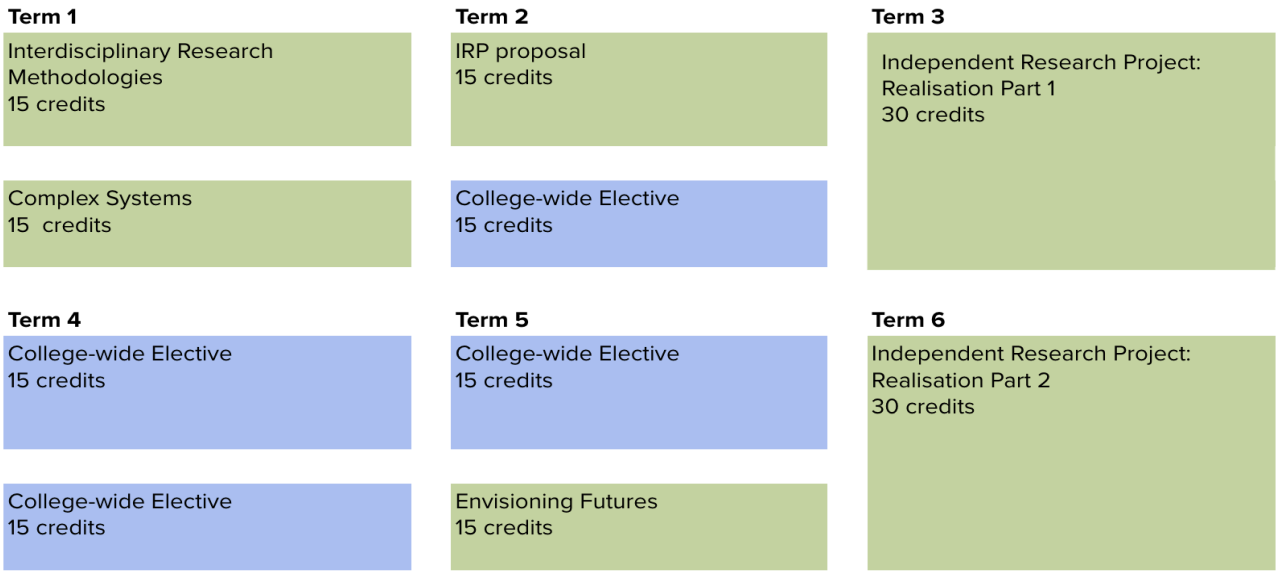
4. What Will I Learn?

Curriculum Map

Full-time:



Part-time:



Programme Structure

Full-time:

Unit Title	Term	Credit Value	Core or Elective?
Research Methodologies	1	15	Core
Complex Systems	1	15	Core
College-wide Electives	1	15	Elective
College-wide Electives	1	15	Elective
Envisioning Futures	2	15	Core
College-wide Electives	2	15	Elective
College-wide Electives	2	15	Elective
Independent Research Project: Proposal	2	15	Core
Independent Research Project: Realisation	3	60	Core

Part-time:

Unit Title	Term	Credit Value	Core or Elective?
Research Methodologies	1	15	Core
Complex Systems	1	15	Core
Independent Research Project: Proposal	2	15	Core
College-wide Electives	2	15	Elective
Independent Research Project: Realisation Part 1	3	30	Core
College-wide Electives	4	15	Elective
College-wide Electives	4	15	Elective
Envisioning Futures	5	15	Core
College-wide Electives	5	15	Elective
Independent Research Project: Realisation Part 2	6	30	Core

Research Methodologies
Introduces research and futures methodologies to support the imagination and realisation of alternative futures by engaging with diverse forms of knowledge, stakeholders and perspectives.

Complex Systems
Introduces the behaviour of systems, how elements interact and disrupt outcomes, and explores how designers can drive and manage change across complexity.

Envisioning Futures
Combines futures methods with advanced digital and analogue envisioning methods bringing to life near and deep futures from a multi-species perspective.

College-wide Electives
These will comprise electives from all RCA Schools.

I**ndependent Research Project (IRP)**
The independent research project (IRP) is the conclusion of your studies on the MDes Design Futures. The IRP is an opportunity for you to propose and realise a body of work that addresses the key ambitions of your research and professional practice. You will draw on what you have learnt on the programme to devise a project which might be individual or collaborative. You will also be encouraged and supported to identify opportunities for the professional public dissemination of your work. Your project will be supported through tutorials and opportunities to share your research developments through seminars and forums.

IRP Full-time
The independent research project is broken down into one 15 credit unit and a final 60 credit unit.

IRP Part-time
The independent research project is broken down into three units: a 15 credit unit and two 30 credit units.

There is one Independent Study week per term included in your programme (three for full-time students and six for part-time students). During these weeks there will be no scheduled teaching or assessment, and limited access to Technical Services. Self-service will be available for inducted users, and you may independently use computing and technology zones, bench spaces, and the resources store and art shop. These weeks are intended for you to work independently, and technical supervision, fabrication support, or supervision of high-risk activities will not be available.

5. How Will I Learn?

Units are delivered through a combination of lectures, seminars, and group tutorials, including in-person and online delivery. Some units require intense on-campus activity in blocks while others are delivered over several months. On-campus activity, group tutorials and peer-led asynchronous activities support and structure your independent study.

You will be encouraged to engage with your network of peers and to collectively contribute to common learning resources, student-led seminars, and peer critique. You are encouraged to engage in collaboration in ways that are informed by your existing experiences of industry and practice. By participating in different activities, you will receive constructive feedback and learn to evaluate your work more effectively.

You are expected to begin the programme with existing technical expertise in the field in which you intend to practise. Any new technical expertise that you wish to acquire in order to realise your proposed projects will be mostly gained through independent access to Technical Services that take place outside of the unit structure on a first come first served basis, and subject to availability. Some units may offer specific access to technical activities.

You are expected to take a professional and independent approach to the programme, including determining your journey through the choice of electives, managing the demands of multiple concurrent units, and working towards deadlines.

Throughout the programme there are opportunities to network with your peers from across the College.

The programme will include a publicly accessible output that will take the form of an exhibition, publication or event. This is where you will work with your peers to collaboratively present the work in progress of your independent research project. The ways in which you contribute to these events will be dependent on the form of your intended outcomes. It is also intended that these events will be additional opportunities to engage interested parties, such as employers or funders.

In this programme, some units have a number of technical contact hours included, such as technical and library orientations & inductions into the use of equipment, spaces and processes required during the unit. If you wish to access other specialist technical equipment, spaces or processes or acquire additional technical or library skills outside of your timetabled unit contact time, you will be required to make independent bookings, which are available on a first-come-first-serve basis from Technical Services and the Library.

Where study visits are a core part of the teaching, these are mostly in the London area and you will only pay for travel expenses. Any extra-curricular visits/trips are optional and will be at your own expense.

Your studies are divided into three terms and comprise scheduled staff-led time such as lectures, seminars and tutorials, as well as independent learning. Each term consists of 60 credits which equates to 600 study hours. During each week you should, as a full-time student, expect about 40 study hours. This is made up of two components:

- contact hours (approximately 5-10 per week) which involve timetabled interaction with tutors (for example, in seminars, critiques and tutorials), fostering intellectual exchange by way of clarifying concepts, addressing key questions and cultivating critical thinking;
- the time you dedicate to developing your work independently (in addition to the contact hours) by way of self-directed study which can include activities such as making in the workshops, working in the studio, conducting research or preparing for assessment.

The amount of time you spend in self-directed, independent study will normally increase as you progress to the final term, particularly as you focus on the public exhibition or completion of your work. The precise pattern of contact hours will vary by unit, term and mode of study.

6. Assessment and Feedback

Regulations
The programme is subject to the Academic Regulations of the Royal College of Art (*the regulations are subject to annual updates and amendments*).

Assessment

Assessment is about what you have learnt on the programme and demonstrating what you will be able to do in the future. Assessment is a continuous process that involves you, your peers and your tutors. Understanding the unit learning outcomes are key to you ensuring that any assessment evidence you submit meets or exceeds the required level.

Formative assessment on the Design Futures programme will include peer-feedback, self-reflective reviews and tutorials.

Summative assessment on the Design Futures programme will include, but will not be limited to, different types of submission including; proposals, bid/pitch documents, reports, presentations (including recorded), project prototypes and models, peer reviews, evaluations, and strategic mapping exercises.

Written feedback will be provided for all summative assessment within 3 working weeks of the date of assessment.

Information regarding individual assessments will be included in the unit descriptors, available at the beginning of the academic year.

7. What Award Can I Get?

To be awarded an RCA MDes degree you need to gain 180 credits at level 7 of the Framework for Higher Education Qualifications (FHEQ). This will involve successfully completing all units.

Exit awards: If you have gained at least 60 credits at Level 7, you may be eligible for the exit award of Postgraduate Certificate. If you have gained at least 120 credits at level 7 of the FHEQ, you may be eligible for the exit award of Postgraduate Diploma.